

The Stay Safe Field Guide

A calm, practical guide to personal safety — from a true-crime publisher that refuses to sell fear.

If you are in immediate danger

Call **911** (or your local emergency number) when it is safe to do so.

Safety is not a test you pass by doing everything perfectly. It is not your job to predict another person's choices, manage their anger, or prove that a situation is “bad enough” before you ask for help.

This guide offers practical ways to notice what is happening, protect your options, and reach trained support. **It is not a substitute for a personalized safety plan from a domestic-violence, stalking, sexual-assault, trafficking, or crisis advocate.** When risk is high, changing quickly, or connected to someone who monitors or controls you, specialized help matters.

You deserve information without blame, fear, or pressure. Take what is useful. Leave what is not. Move at the pace that is safest for you.

The patterns below are common — far more common than most people realize. Learning to recognize them protects you, and it helps you recognize when someone you care about may be in trouble too. That is the whole of our mission: **no more victims.**

Start With Awareness, Not Fear

Situational awareness does not mean living on high alert. It means giving yourself enough attention and information to make choices.

When you enter a place, quietly notice the basics: where you are, who is nearby, how you would leave, and where you could go if you needed help. Keep your phone accessible when practical. In unfamiliar settings, consider letting a trusted person know where you are and when you expect to check in.

Awareness also includes changes. A person, vehicle, account, message pattern, or repeated “coincidence” may deserve attention when it begins to form a pattern. One event may be harmless. Repetition, persistence, boundary-testing, or escalation can change the meaning.

You do not have to confront someone to validate your concern. Moving toward other people, entering a staffed business, changing your route, calling someone, or asking an employee for assistance are reasonable choices. **The goal is not to appear fearless. The goal is to preserve choices.**

Trust the Signal Before You Can Explain It

People often notice danger first as discomfort: a tight feeling, mental fog, a sudden wish to leave, or the sense that something does not fit. That feeling is information, even when you cannot yet name the reason.

Courtesy is optional when your safety is involved. You can end a conversation, refuse a ride, step out of an elevator, cancel a meeting, block an account, or ask for help without presenting a case.

If the concern involves a partner, former partner, family member, coworker, or other known person, your instincts may be responding to a pattern that outsiders cannot see. You are the expert on the day-to-day reality. A trained advocate can help you examine that pattern without ordering you to leave or blaming you for staying.

Recognize Control, Not Just Physical Violence

Harm often begins before any physical assault. Coercive control is a pattern of domination that reduces another person's freedom and independence. It may include monitoring, isolation, intimidation, financial control, threats, humiliation, sexual pressure, or rules that apply only to one person.

Warning signs can include someone who:

- bullet Demands constant access to your location, passwords, phone, or accounts.
- bullet Decides who you may see, where you may go, what you may wear, or how you may spend money.
- bullet Punishes independence with rage, silence, threats, public embarrassment, or accusations.
- bullet Uses children, pets, housing, immigration status, disability, employment, private images, or finances as leverage.
- bullet Threatens self-harm, harm to others, or ruin unless you comply.
- bullet Treats jealousy, surveillance, or possession as proof of love.
- bullet Repeatedly ignores a clear "no," then minimizes the behavior or says you caused it.

No single checklist can diagnose a relationship. The important question is whether a pattern is shrinking your freedom, increasing your fear, or making ordinary choices feel dangerous.

The responsibility belongs to the person choosing control or harm. A failure to calm someone down is not consent, complicity, or fault.

Take Stalking and Escalation Seriously

Stalking is more than unwanted attention. It is a course of conduct that causes fear or serious emotional distress. It may happen in person, through technology, through other people, or across several channels at once. Possible signs include:

- bullet Repeated unwanted calls, texts, or messages.
- bullet Showing up at your home, work, or regular places.
- bullet Following you, or seeming to always know where you are.
- bullet Unwanted gifts, letters, or deliveries.
- bullet Property damage, or impersonating you online.
- bullet Account intrusion, location tracking, or monitoring your devices.
- bullet Contacting your friends or relatives to gather information about you.
- bullet Threatening to reveal private material.

Escalation matters. Concern rises when contact becomes more frequent, more intrusive, more threatening, or more focused on punishment and control. Separation, blocked access, legal action, job loss, public exposure, weapon access, threats, a history of strangulation, and violations of protective boundaries can be important risk factors that deserve specialist attention.

Do not assume you must personally warn, confront, or negotiate with someone who is stalking you. Direct contact can sometimes increase danger or provide the response the person is seeking.

Preserve evidence when doing so is safe. Save messages, voicemails, screenshots, dates, locations, witness names, damaged-property photos, and police or platform report numbers. Store copies somewhere the person cannot access.

Protect Your Digital Space

Digital safety is personal safety. Phones, shared accounts, vehicles, smart-home devices, cloud photos, family plans, and social platforms can reveal location, routines, contacts, and private conversations.

Begin with the possibility that changing settings may alert a person who is monitoring you. If that could raise the risk, use a safer device or speak with an advocate before making major changes.

Useful steps may include reviewing account recovery emails and phone numbers, using unique passwords, enabling multifactor authentication, checking active sessions and connected devices, limiting location sharing, reviewing app permissions, and tightening social-media privacy. Consider what friends and relatives post about you.

Blocking can be helpful, but it is not always the safest first step in a stalking or coercive-control situation. It may erase access to evidence, trigger escalation, or cause the person to switch methods.

De-escalation Is an Option, Not an Obligation

In a tense encounter, simple communication may sometimes lower immediate friction: keep your voice steady, use short sentences, avoid unnecessary argument, maintain physical space, and move toward an exit or other people. Do not make sudden movements around someone who appears highly agitated or armed.

But there is no perfect phrase that controls another person's behavior. Leaving, calling for help, drawing attention, or complying temporarily to survive can all be valid responses.

A good advocate should support your agency. They should not demand that you leave, shame you for returning, or treat one plan as safe for everyone. Leaving can be a dangerous period, and careful planning may be more protective than an impulsive exit.

Current Support Resources

Domestic violence & coercive control

National Domestic Violence Hotline — TheHotline.org. Call **800-799-SAFE (7233)** or text **START** to **88788**. Advocates can discuss domestic abuse, coercive control, safety planning, and local services.

Stalking

Stalking Prevention, Awareness & Resource Center (SPARC) — StalkingAwareness.org. Provides stalking information and can help you understand documentation, risk, and connections to local victim-service providers. It is not an emergency hotline.

Human trafficking

National Human Trafficking Hotline — HumanTraffickingHotline.org. Call **888-373-7888** or text **233733** for specialized trafficking support and referrals.

Sexual assault

RAINN National Sexual Assault Hotline — RAINN.org. Call **800-656-HOPE (4673)** or use the online chat for confidential sexual-assault support.

Crisis support

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline — Call or text **988**, or chat at 988lifeline.org, for suicide, mental-health, or substance-use crisis support. 988 is not a general crime-reporting line and does not replace 911 for immediate physical danger.

Eating disorders

National Association of Anorexia Nervosa and Associated Disorders (ANAD) — ANAD.org. The current ANAD helpline is **888-375-7767**.

When using a shared or monitored device, consider clearing browsing history only if doing so will not create suspicion. Many advocacy sites offer a quick-exit feature, but a quick exit does not erase browser history.

A Small Plan Is Still a Plan

You do not need to solve everything today. One useful action may be enough for now: save a number under a neutral name, identify a safer device, tell one trustworthy person, photograph an important document, change one recovery address, pack medication, record one incident, or speak privately with an advocate.

Safety planning is not a promise that harm will never happen. It is a way to increase options and reduce isolation. **The person causing harm remains responsible for the harm.**

You deserve to be believed. You deserve choices. You deserve support that respects your reality.

Neural Edge Publishing covers crime without turning suffering into spectacle. Our work is victim-first, sourced, and built around one mission: **NO MORE VICTIMS**.

This guide is not a substitute for a personalized safety plan from a trained advocate. Read the full guide, always current, at cassiancreed.com/safety/